

ONE

IS JESUS REALLY GOD?

Read Introduction, John 1:1–18;
other references as given.

John 1:1–18 forms the introduction (or prologue) to the fourth gospel. In this passage the apostle John introduces us to a number of key words and phrases that dominate the remainder of the book: *witness, Word, life, light, darkness, belief, and truth*.

It is here that we're also introduced to another John. John the Baptist was a transitional figure between the Old and New Testaments and a mighty witness for Christ. Like the Old Testament prophets before him, John the Baptist preached a powerful message of repentance. Like the New Testament apostles and prophets, he bore witness to Jesus as the promised Messiah and the sinless Son of God.

Before you begin, please ask God to reveal Himself through His Word and to give you grace to accept the truths you will be learning.

1. The gospels of Matthew, Mark, and Luke begin with a bold declaration that Jesus is God, but John's gospel begins with a powerful theological statement in the form of a riddle. Rather than simply telling us who Jesus is, John invites his readers to discover Jesus' true identity for themselves.

a. *What do you think* are the three most common opinions about who Jesus Christ was or is?



Lombardi Time Principle

When the leader arrives 10-15 minutes early, he or she has time to pray, prepare the room, and greet the participants personally.

ADD GROUP
INSIGHTS BELOW

b. Who *do you think* Jesus was or is, and why?

2. If you are somewhat familiar with the Bible, likely you realize that the first words of John 1:1 (**In the beginning was the Word**) are similar to the first words in the Bible (Genesis 1:1, **In the beginning God**).

a. Genesis 1 describes the new *physical* creation; John's gospel describes the new *spiritual* creation (life in Christ). In both verses the phrase **in the beginning** refers to the same event. To what event or time *do you think* it refers?

b. John 1:1 says **In the beginning was**, not "in the beginning *is*." What or who was in existence before "the beginning" (Genesis 1:1–2; John 1:1)?

3. Use of the term *Word* in John 1:1 may seem strange to you. To Greeks (non-Jews or Gentiles), *word* meant not only the spoken word but also the thought (or reasoning of the mind) before the words were spoken. To the Hebrews, *Word* meant God's revelation to man (cf. Genesis 15:1, **The Word of the Lord came to Abram**). John's use of the term *Word* (John 1:1, Gk. *logos*) was uniquely powerful, meaning "ultimate

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reason" to the Greeks and "ultimate revelation" (from God) to the Jews.

- a. To this point in our study the true identity of the **Word** has not been disclosed. List at least four important truths the Bible teaches about the **Word** (John 1:1–3).

- b. Which words and phrases are used to emphasize that all creation is the direct result of the **Word's** creative power, rather than evolution or a by-product of chance such as the "Big Bang" theory (John 1:3, 10; Colossians 1:16)?

4. The best commentary (or interpretative aid) on the Bible is the Bible itself. Use the following verses to determine the exact identity of the **Word** in John 1:1–3, and support your interpretation with specific verse references (John 1:1, 2, 14, 17).



*Would you like
to learn how to
disciple another
person, lead a
life-changing
Bible study, or
start a new study?
Lamplighters Int'l
ministries can help
guide you.*

ADDITIONAL
INSIGHTS

ADDITIONAL
ANSWERS

5. What do you think is the meaning of the phrase **In Him was life** (John 1:4)?

6. Some Christians don't seem to believe that **the light shines in the darkness** (John 1:5). Rather than believing that God's light (truth) overcomes the darkness (sin) of this world, they live and speak as if the darkness is an unstoppable force that irresistibly overwhelms the light of God's truth. If Christians don't grasp the truth of God's power over sin, they could be tempted to (1) withdraw from the world (isolation), (2) allow themselves to be assimilated into the world (worldliness), or (3) live in defeat and complain about the advancement of wickedness in society (including state schools and government).

- a. If you are a Christian, do you truly believe that "the light [of Christ] shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it" (John 1:5, NIV), or do you believe the darkness overcomes the light?

- b. Are you living in spiritual defeat, overcome by fear and forsaking biblical responsibilities to be a witness for Christ? Or are you living in the light, experiencing victory in Christ and boldly spreading the message of Christ to those in spiritual darkness?

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- c. What specific things could you do to let Christ's light shine through you more brightly at home ... at work... in your church ... in your community?

7. John the Baptist was a mighty servant of God. Jesus said, **among those born of women there is not a greater prophet than John the Baptist** (Luke 7:28).

- a. What was the sole purpose of John the Baptist's life (John 1:6-8)?

- b. Just before Jesus ascended into heaven (Acts 1:9-11), He commanded His followers to be His witnesses (Acts 1:8). In what way do you think John the Baptist's ministry and a New Testament Christian's ministry are similar?

8. a. Jesus came into the world He created (John 1:3; Colossians 1:16), but those He created rejected Him (John 1:10-11). On what basis does a person become a child of God (John 1:12-13)?



Using table tents will help visitors feel more comfortable when they attend the group. If you are meeting online, encourage the participants to "rename" themselves if necessary.

ADDITIONAL
INSIGHTS

ADDITIONAL
INSTRUCTIONS

- b. List three common misconceptions (false beliefs that are unacceptable to God [John 1:13]) many people believe about how they can enter heaven.

9. Most Christians tend to live lives that are either truth-based or grace-based. Those who conduct themselves strictly based on truth often lack grace in their lives. Those who rely heavily on grace often lack the spiritual courage to stand up for the truth. Jesus, however, was **full of grace and truth** (John 1:14, emphasis added). What do you think that means?
